ATT&CK® EVALUATIONS · METHODOLOGY

HOW WE TEST.
HOW WE SCORE.
WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU.

ATT&CK® Evaluations test security products against real adversary behaviors in controlled, transparent conditions — with no vendor-controlled demos, no cherry-picked results. This page explains our methodology and the new scoring framework for Enterprise 2026.

ALL READERS FOR CUSTOMERS FOR VENDORS

DESIGN PRINCIPLES

What this methodology is built on

The ATT&CK Evaluations methodology is designed around four core principles — each of which shapes specific decisions in how scenarios are designed, how the test environment is built, how results are collected, and how scores are calculated.

Intelligence-Driven Scenarios

Every scenario begins with structured CTI analysis of real adversary campaigns — not theoretical threat models or vendor-proposed scenarios. Adversary selection is driven by prevalence data and

Behavior Over Signatures

The evaluation tests whether a solution detects what an adversary *did* — not whether it recognized a specific tool or file hash. This forces solutions to demonstrate genuine behavioral coverage rather than IOC-matching, and

Methodological Transparency

The complete methodology — scoring formulas, technique scope, test environment specifications, and results data — is published openly. Vendors receive the same documentation customers

entries with supporting intelligence.

- ✔ Adversary selection driven by real-world prevalence
- ✔ Technique scope derived from observed campaign TTPs
- ✔ All emulation plans published openly in the AEL
- ✔ ATT&CK-mapped at sub-technique level

who change tooling frequently.

- ✔ No pre-notification of specific tools or techniques
- ✔ Detection quality scored on behavioral context, not alert presence
- ✔ Living-off-the-land techniques designed to stress signal/noise
- ✔ Sub-technique specificity maintained throughout scoring

- ✔ Full methodology specification published pre-evaluation
- ✔ Complete telemetry and screenshots published with results
- ✔ Scoring components individually calculable from raw data
- ✔ Emulation plans open-source under Apache 2.0

🔄 CONTINUOUS EVOLUTION

The methodology evolves to reflect how the threat landscape changes. Each cycle incorporates lessons from prior evaluations, feedback from participating vendors and end users, and new adversary tradecraft emerging in the wild. Enterprise 2026 introduces the most significant methodological evolution to date: the Total Evaluation Score (TES) framework and unified Source-of-Action attribution — moving the program from qualitative per-technique results to quantified, comparable performance metrics across all vendor types.

HOW WE TEST

Four Teams. One structured process.

Each evaluation is produced by four specialized teams. Three work in sequence before execution week — Cyber Threat Intelligence, Red Development, and Detection Engineering — building the scenario, the environment, and the scoring criteria. The Execution Team then runs the evaluation, operating the adversary emulation and coordinating directly with vendors throughout their assigned week. Each phase has defined outputs and handoff criteria. No phase can begin until the prior phase's outputs are validated.

1 2 3

Adversary

CTI analysis begins with structured review of public threat intelligence: campaign reports, malware analyses, incident disclosures, and government advisories. The team selects adversaries based on prevalence and enterprise impact, then builds adversary profiles that catalog all observed TTPs, tools, infrastructure, and operational patterns. Each technique in scope is mapped to a specific ATT&CK entry — with the intelligence source cited — before the Red team begins operationalization.

PHASE OUTPUTS

- Adversary selection rationale
- ATT&CK technique scope
- Intelligence summary
- Emulation plan (CTI layer)

The Red Development team takes the CTI-produced adversary profile and operationalizes it into a complete, executable intrusion scenario against the test environment. This involves building or acquiring representative tooling, developing step-by-step procedures for each technique, designing the victim network architecture to support realistic attack chains, and executing rehearsal runs to validate that each step produces expected telemetry. The result is a documented, repeatable adversary emulation plan with machine-readable procedures.

PHASE OUTPUTS

- Executable emulation plan
- Test environment spec
- Step-by-step procedures
- Expected telemetry artifacts

The Detection Engineering team analyzes the adversary footprint produced by the Red Development team to establish what a well-configured defender should be able to detect — and at what quality level. For each technique, the team defines detection criteria: what data sources are required, what behavioral indicators are observable, and what level of context a high-quality alert should contain. These criteria become the scoring rubric used during evaluation execution. The team also defines the false positive test cases run alongside adversary activity.

PHASE OUTPUTS

- Detection criteria per technique
- Alert quality rubric
- False positive test cases
- Scoring thresholds

4

EXECUTION TEAM

Running the Evaluation

The Execution Team operates the evaluation during each vendor's assigned week. Red Team Operators execute the adversary emulation procedures against the live test environment while Threat Hunt Coordinators interface directly with the vendor's technical contacts — managing communication, observing vendor tooling in real time, and

week.

EXECUTION WEEK ROLES

- Red Team Operators
- Threat Hunt Coordinators
- Vendor technical liaison
- Live results documentation

🏗️ **Infrastructure Team:** A dedicated Infrastructure team designs, builds, and maintains the test ranges that all four phases depend on. Vendors will work directly with this team during Weeks 1–2 of their execution window — environment access, network connectivity, and range-level configuration issues are coordinated through them. The Infrastructure team remains available throughout execution week to support any environment-related needs.

💡 **Core philosophy:** Behavior over signatures. Quality over quantity. One high-quality, actionable alert that tells an analyst who did what, when, where, and why is more valuable than dozens of low-context notifications — and the DQI scoring framework reflects this directly.

NEW FOR ENTERPRISE 2026

The Total Evaluation Score (TES)

Enterprise 2026 introduces a unified quantitative scoring framework. The TES combines detection quality and protection quality into a single comparable score — with a modifier that tells you *how* the score was achieved.

TES = DQI + PQI

Scale: 0.0 – 2.0 | Or expressed as TES/2.0 = 0–100%

DQI

Why two dimensions?

Detection and protection measure different things. A vendor that detects everything but blocks nothing differs fundamentally from one that blocks early but provides no visibility. TES captures both

PQI	Protection Quality Index — how effectively threats are blocked at the right time (0–1)
Mod	Who produced the result: (P) Platform · (P/AI) Platform+AI · (S/H) Service/Human · (S/AI) Service/AI · Mixed
TES	Combined score. Higher = better combined detection and protection quality

The Source-of-Action modifier (shown in parentheses after the score) tells you *who* produced the result: automated platform, human analysts, or AI. Same score, different operational meaning.

Cookie Preferences